HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Purity of Motives and Compassion: HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem, Chapters 3-4

Given Monday 9 March 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Kifayat al-Abidin) — Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam **Chapters:** Perek 3 (טהרת המעשים — Purity of Action) & Perek 4 (רחמנות — Mercy/Compassion) **Edition:** Feldheim

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Chapter 3: טהרת המעשים — Purity of Action

Recap: Chapters 1–2

- **Chapter 1:** Two paths of Avodat Hashem — Derech Ha'am (the common path of fulfilling mitzvot) and Derech HaYachid/Chasid (the deeper path of those who seek closeness to Hashem). The purpose of this sefer is the path of the Chasid.
- **Chapter 2:** All middot are interrelated — working on one naturally affects others, and vice versa.

The Two Extremes of Motivation

Chapter 3 presents two polar extremes of why a person performs mitzvot, and then two intermediate levels between them.

Level 4 (Lowest): Mitzvot Shelo Lishmah — For Other People

The worst level: a person performs mitzvot **only because of societal pressure**. He doesn't want to be caught out, doesn't want to show face. If he were certain there would be no social consequences, he would abandon the mitzvot entirely and commit aveirot freely.

Rabbi Avraham says this is so obvious he shouldn't even need to mention it. HaKadosh Baruch Hu looks into the heart — He doesn't want people just going through the motions for external appearances.

Nevertheless: Even this level is better than doing nothing at all. As Chazal say: מתוך שלא לשמה בא לשמה — From doing mitzvot for the wrong motives, a person may eventually come to do them for the right motives.

Level 1 (Highest): Tahara Gemura — Complete Purity / Serving from Love

The completely pure level — המדרגה טהורה גמורה

This person performs mitzvot **solely because HaKadosh Baruch Hu commanded them**, with no regard for what other people think.

Two scenarios that don't affect this person:

1. **If people think he is righteous** but deep down he feels he isn't — he is filled with fear and trepidation before Hashem, because he knows the truth regardless of external perception.
2. **If people think he is NOT righteous** but deep down he knows he is doing everything for Hashem — he pays no attention to their judgment.

ולכן יש מהם שאמרו יהי חלקי עם מי שחשדין אותו ואין בו

One of the Amoraim said: "Let my portion be with those who are suspected but have nothing [wrong] in them."

Important Qualification: והייתם נקיים מה' ומישראל

This does NOT mean a person should **deliberately act** in a way that arouses suspicion. The Yerushalmi Shekalim teaches — based on Moshe Rabbeinu giving a full accounting in Parshat Pekudei (because people questioned his wealth from the פסולת of the Luchot) — that just as a person must appear correct before Hashem, he must also appear correct before other people.

The distinction: If you are acting correctly and people still suspect you — ignore them. If your behaviour is actually causing suspicion — you must address it.

Dovid HaMelech's Confidence

> Examine me, Hashem, test me, refine my kidneys and my heart (Tehillim — בחנני ה' ונסני צרפה כליותי ולבי 26:2)

> Search me, God, and know my heart; test me and know my thoughts — חקרני אל ודע לבבי בחנני ודע שרעפי (Tehillim 139:23)

Dovid was comfortable inviting Hashem to examine his innermost being because he felt his motives were completely pure.

The Essence of This Level

שעושה מעשיו רק כדי לקיים מצותו שהוא חובת הציווי

A person does everything **only to fulfill Hashem's command — because it is an obligation.** As the pasuk says: וזכרת כי עבד היית במצרים ושמרת ועשית את החוקים האלה — "Remember you were a servant in Egypt, and you shall keep these laws." Rabbi Avraham interprets: You were once a servant to Par'oh; now you are a servant of HaKadosh Baruch Hu — therefore you keep the mitzvot.

Three things this person does NOT do mitzvot for:

1. **Not for reward** — even though Hashem will certainly reward him.
2. **Not for fear of punishment** — even though Hashem certainly punishes.
3. **Even in a hypothetical where Hashem would punish for keeping mitzvot** — he would still keep them. Even if told there would be no punishment for violating — he would still not violate.

This is called עובד מאהבה — serving from love.

The Rambam's Parallel (Hilchot Teshuva, Chapter 10)

אל יאמר אדם הריני עושה מצוות התורה כדי שאקבל כל הברכות... כדי שאזכה לחיי העולם הבא

Don't do mitzvot for blessings or even for Olam Haba.

Critical point from the Rambam: Even serving Hashem **in order to receive Olam Haba** is classified as עובד מיראה (serving from fear), not love. This is because wanting reward and fearing punishment are ultimately the same thing in Rambam's framework — punishment IS the lack of reward (loss of Olam Haba).

העובד מאהבה... עושה האמת מפני שהוא אמת — Does the truth because it is the truth.

ומעלה זו היא מעלה גדולה מאד ואין כל חכם זוכה לה — This is an exceedingly great level, and not every sage merits it.

Level 2: Serving from Fear (עובד מיראה)

A person who keeps mitzvot because of **fear of Hashem's punishment** or **desire for Hashem's reward** — but NOT because of any human element.

- No societal pressure involved — it's all directed toward God
- But it's still self-serving: if you were guaranteed no punishment, you wouldn't keep the mitzvot
- This includes: fear of losing Olam Haba AND desire to gain Olam Haba

As Rabbeinu Bachya ibn Paquda writes in Chovot HaLevavot: as long as a person serves for something — whether fear or reward — ultimately he is serving himself.

Level 3: Dual Motivation — For Hashem AND for People

A person who performs mitzvot **both for Hashem and for social recognition.** He gets dual satisfaction — he fulfils the command AND enjoys the prestige.

Example: Learning Torah both to understand what Hashem requires AND to be known as a talmid chacham. Praying Shacharit both because it's obligatory AND because he wants people to see him praying.

> לא תעשם עטרה להתגדל בהם ולא קרדום לחפור בהם — Don't make the Torah a crown to glorify yourself or a spade to dig with (Pirkei Avot)

Summary: The Four Levels

Level	Motivation	Category
Level 1 (Highest)	Only because Hashem commanded — no reward, no fear	עובד מאהבה
Level 2	Fear of Hashem's punishment / desire for Hashem's reward	עובד מיראה
Level 3	For Hashem AND for social recognition	Mixed — shelo lishmah element
Level 4 (Lowest)	Only for societal pressure — would abandon if no consequences	Shelo lishmah

Practical Reflection

Rabbi Avraham acknowledges this is a very high level — even great Chachamim struggle to reach Level 1. The purpose of studying this is to **intellectually grasp the goal** and aspire toward it.

Questions to ask ourselves: Why do I keep Shabbat? Why do I put on tefillin? Why do I learn Torah? Is it because everyone else does it (Level 4)? For recognition (Level 3)? For reward/fear (Level 2)? Or because Hashem commanded me and this is the best way to live (Level 1)?

Different mitzvot may come from different levels within us — and the goal is to gradually move upward.

Chapter 4: רחמנות — Mercy / Compassion

The Meaning of Rachamanut

The word רחמנות comes from the three-letter root רחם (rechem) — a womb.

Two explanations:

1. **The maternal bond:** The greatest example of mercy and compassion in humanity is the love of a mother for her child. As Yeshayahu says (49:15): התשכח אשה עולה מרחם בן בטנה — "Can a nursing woman forget, from having mercy on her child?" The pasuk uses מרחם — the same root — connecting womb to mercy.
2. **Seeing people as developing:** A rechem/womb represents growth and development. We naturally have patience and compassion for people who are growing (e.g., a baby crying on a plane). Rachamanut means seeing others as developing, still in their "womb" of growth — and therefore extending compassion.

Rachamanut as a Foundation of Torah

הרחמנות היא מן המידות הטרומיות ומטרות התורה — Compassion is one of the lofty character traits and one of the purposes of the Torah.

Rabbi Avraham identifies this as the **first specific middah** he discusses (likely because it is the first of the 13 Attributes of Mercy: אל רחום וחנון).

והיא התכונה הראשונה מבין התכונות המיוחדות לישראל — It is the first of the special character traits of Israel.

Torah Mitzvot That Train Compassion

The Torah gave us many mitzvot specifically to soften indifference and develop mercy:

- **Tzedakah** — supporting the poor and needy
- **Returning collateral (השבת עבוט)** — if you take a poor person's garment as collateral, you must return it at night so he can sleep. The Torah even gives the reason: כי היא כסותו לבדה היא שמלתו לעורו במה ישכב — "It is his only covering, his garment for his skin — what shall he sleep in?"

לא תאמץ את לבבך — Do not harden your heart" (in the context of giving charity)"

The Prohibition of Achzariyut (Cruelty/Indifference)

The word אכזריות comes from the root זר (zar) — a stranger/foreigner. Cruelty at its root is **indifference** — treating someone as a stranger, as if their suffering has nothing to do with you.

Key insight: You don't have to be actively cruel to be guilty of achzariyut. Simply not caring about someone's plight is achzariyut.

Tzedakah Requires Empathy — Not Just Money (Rambam, Hilchot Matanot Aniyim)

The Rambam rules:

כל הנותן צדקה לעני בסבר פנים רעות ופניו כבושות בקרקע אפילו נתן לו אלף זהובים איבד זכותו והפסידה

If you give charity with an unfriendly face, looking down — even if you give a thousand gold coins — you have lost your merit.

אלא נותנו בסבר פנים יפות ובשמחה ומתאונן עמו על צרתו

Rather, give with a pleasant face, with joy, and **empathize with his suffering**.

Source: Iyov 30:25 — אם לא בכיתי לקשה יום עגמה נפשי לאביון — "Did I not weep for the one whose day was hard? Was my soul not grieved for the poor?"

Sympathy vs. Empathy:

- **Sympathy:** Understanding someone's suffering from the outside — "I can see why you're sad."
- **Empathy:** Actually feeling their pain from within — sharing in their suffering.

The Rambam's halacha requires **empathy**, not just sympathy. Part of the mitzvah of tzedakah is attempting to feel the other person's pain.

When Mercy Is Wrong — Misplaced Compassion

Rabbi Avraham warns: rachamanut does not mean being soft-hearted and impressionable in every situation. True mercy requires **wisdom** — knowing when to be compassionate and when to be firm.

The Torah commands firmness in specific cases:

- **A murderer** — מעם מזבחי תקחנו למות — even from the altar, take him to die. Even if he seeks refuge with Hashem Himself, do not show mercy. (Rambam in Moreh Nevuchim explains: the mizbeach represents seeking refuge with the highest authority — even that doesn't help.)
- **A meisit (one who entices to idolatry)** — לא תחמול ולא תכסה עליו — do not have pity, even if it is your own son.
- **A ben sorer u'moreh (rebellious son)** — parents must bring him to Beit Din.

Examples from the Prophets: Mercy and Firmness Together

Moshe Rabbeinu — within two or three pesukim:

- Kills the Egyptian who was beating a Jew (firmness)
- Saves the daughters of Yitro and waters their flock (compassion)

The same person. Because mercy must be applied correctly.

Dovid HaMelech:

- Compassion for the poor man's lamb (the parable of Natan HaNavi)
- Harshness toward the Ammonim (killing with saws and iron implements)

Shmuel HaNavi:

- Killed Agag (וישסף שמואל את אגג לפני ה')

HaKadosh Baruch Hu Himself

Even Hashem, who is רחום וחנון ארך אפים ורב חסד — also:

פוקד עון אבות על בנים — remembers sins

כי ה' אלוהיך אש אוכלה הוא אל קנא — Hashem is a consuming fire, a jealous God

- Moshe, who heard the 13 Attributes of Mercy, still declared Hashem is "a consuming fire"

Mercy and justice coexist — and knowing when to apply each is the mark of true wisdom.

The Gemara's Principle

כל מי שיש בו מידת הרחמנות הקדוש ברוך הוא מרחם עליו — Whoever has the trait of mercy, HaKadosh Baruch Hu has mercy on him.

Source: ונתן לך רחמים ורחמך והרבך — "He will give you mercy and have mercy on you and multiply you."

But also:

אין מרחמים אלא על מי שיש בו דעת — Only have mercy on one who has understanding.

This will be elaborated on in the next shiur — the idea that mercy must be applied with discernment, not indiscriminately.

Key Takeaways

1. **Purity of motive** has four levels — from doing mitzvot only for people (lowest) to doing them solely because Hashem commanded (highest).
2. **Even serving Hashem for Olam Haba** is classified as serving from fear, not love (Rambam and Rabbi Avraham agree on this).
3. **The goal** is to intellectually understand Level 1 and aspire toward it, even if we can't fully reach it.
4. **Rachamanut (mercy)** is the first specific middah discussed — rooted in the maternal bond (rechem) and the recognition that people are developing.
5. **True tzedakah** requires empathy, not just money — feel the person's pain.
6. **Achzariyut (cruelty)** at its root is indifference — treating others as strangers.
7. **Mercy must be applied wisely** — there are times the Torah demands firmness, even harshness. Misplaced compassion is itself a form of wrong.
8. **When in doubt** — be merciful. (To be elaborated next time.)

Preview: Next Shiur

- Completing the discussion of rachmanut — mercy when in doubt
- The meaning of "only have mercy on one who has understanding"
- **Chapter 5:** נדיבות — Generosity

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